

HEMANT CHAWLA



POWER OF TWO: Manmohan and Sonia ensure a clear separation of politics and governance

Gandhi-in-waiting is very much on the move nowadays. His Discovery of India mission is taking him to the dusty remoteness of India. Power is his entitlement—and no Congressman will dispute that. Singh happens to be the only Congressman who is not scared of being a “sycophant”—and has the licence to announce the obvious. And Manmohan happens to be his predictable victim. The prime minister has shrunk further.

In the beginning, Singh even got the necessary endorsements, much to the discomfort of Manmohan. External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee liked the idea and allies like NCP and DMK also sided with him. And it is not the first time Singh has played the Rahul card. When he brought up the Gandhi scion's candidacy in Bhopal some time ago, he was not reprimanded. Even in the latest instance, the Congress spokesperson waited for over 48 hours to deliver the rebuff. “ACC would like to end all speculation. There is no vacancy for the post of prime minister. Both Soniaji and Rahulji have always kept away from any sycophancy,” said Jayanti Natarajan. Sonia had to rescue Manmohan from intra-party humili-

ation, and she did. Later, Singh called on Sonia. Or, was he summoned? He said that he met her to discuss the inauguration of the Indira Gandhi University in Amarkantak in Madhya Pradesh. “I don't have to depend on you to tell me who is happy with me and who isn't. I usually don't take my words back. I don't see anything wrong in what I have said,” he told the media, hardly sounding like a man snubbed.

Unfortunately for Manmohan, the thakur is not the only Cabinet minister who sees him as a stop-gap arrangement. Whether it is an old-timer like Hansraj Bharadwaj or A.K. Antony, or a lightweight like Shivraj Patil, most Congressmen have a direct hotline to 10 Janpath. As do allies Lalu Prasad Yadav, M. Karunanidhi and Ram Vilas Paswan. While leaders like Mukherjee and Singh see themselves as upstaged and overlooked, the Left has always treated Manmohan with suspicion. By keeping the allies management with herself, Sonia has taken some of the prime ministerial prerogative away from Race Course Road.

Her role as UPA chairperson has also extended to government policy making. Whatever achievements there are to the prime minister's credit, as

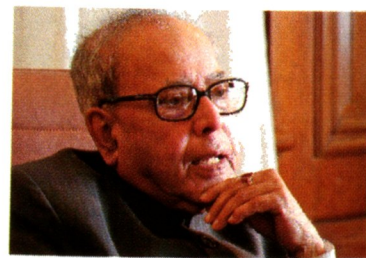
“WHAT IS WRONG IN PROJECTING RAHUL AS PRIME MINISTER?”

ARJUN SINGH,
HRD MINISTER



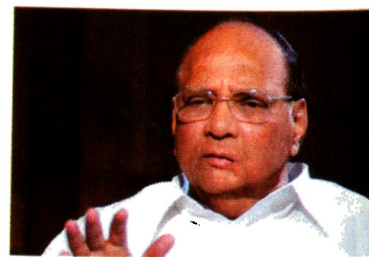
“LEADERSHIP ALWAYS GOES TO YOUNGER PEOPLE. IT IS A UNIVERSAL TRUTH.”

PRANAB MUKHERJEE,
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER



“IT IS FOR THE CONGRESS TO CHOOSE SONIA OR RAHUL GANDHI AS ITS PM.”

SHARAD PAWAR,
NCP PRESIDENT



“I WILL BE HAPPY IF RAHUL IS MADE THE PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE.”

M. KARUNANIDHI,
DMK PRESIDENT

